BERRY AND BAY LAUREL SORBET

makes about 1 quart

Most advice about California bay leaves is to use them carefully, because their flavor is stronger than that of the Mediterranean variety. When adding them to stews, people recommend starting with a single leaf. But here, I encourage you to lean into its sweet, herbal flavor and use a whopping 12 leaves to create a concentrated syrup that then flavors a berry sorbet. If you prefer a less intense bay flavor, you can, of course, reduce the number of leaves.

½ cup agave syrup

12 fresh California bay leaves

3 cups frozen local berries, such as blackberries, huckleberries, thimbleberries, or strawberries

In a medium saucepan, combine the agave syrup and 2 tablespoons water and heat over medium heat until barely bubbling at the edges. Add the bay leaves, being sure they're submerged, and simmer gently for 2 minutes, then turn off the heat. Let the syrup cool to room temperature, then discard the bay leaves.

In a high-powered blender, combine the berries and bay-infused syrup and puree until smooth, using the machine's plunger as needed.

Serve the sorbet immediately. (Alternatively, scoop the sorbet into a loaf pan lined with wax paper and freeze until firm, at least 2 hours. Let stand at room temperature for 10 minutes before scooping.)